

HOUSE No. 4423

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES, September 8, 2025.

The committee on Agriculture and Fisheries, to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 128) of Vanna Howard relative to establishing a food justice frontline providing compensated work involving food production, distribution, preparation, or delivery for food insecure residents, reports recommending that the accompanying bill (House, No. 4423) ought to pass.

For the committee,

NATALIE M. BLAIS.

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In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act relative to establishing a food justice frontline.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. Chapter 18 of the General Laws is hereby amended by inserting after
2 section 2B the following 2 sections:

3 Section 2C. (a) As used in this section, the following words shall have the following
4 meanings, unless the context clearly requires otherwise.

5 “Department”, the department of transitional assistance.

6 “Food security job”, any financially compensated work involving food production, food
7 distribution, food preparation, or food delivery for food insecure Massachusetts residents.

8 “Nonprofit food security organization”, an organization that is exempt from taxation
9 under section 501(c) of the Internal Revenue Code and that has programs which: (1) provide land
10 to low- and moderate-income individuals for agricultural production; or (2) has programs which
11 provide food security jobs to low- and moderate-income individuals, including, but not limited
12 to, food production jobs, food distribution jobs, food preparation jobs, and food delivery jobs.

“Overburdened community” means a census block group in Massachusetts that meets the following criteria:

(1) Is at or above the 75th statewide percentile for at least 2 of the following environmental indicators on the most recent available United States Environmental Protection Agency’s EJSCREEN assessment: (a) PM 2.5; (b) ozone; (c) NATA diesel PM; (d) NATA cancer risk; (e) NATA respiratory hazard index; (f) traffic proximity; (g) lead paint indicator; (h) superfund proximity; (i) risk management plan facilities proximity; (j) hazardous waste proximity; and (k) wastewater discharge indicator; and

(2) has a median household income that is no greater than 80% of the statewide median household income as calculated by the US Census Bureau.

(b) The department shall create the food justice frontline program.

(c) The food justice frontline program shall fund nonprofit food security organizations for the purpose of creating and sustaining food security jobs to individuals living within overburdened communities.

(d) The department shall create an application with which nonprofit food security organizations may apply to receive a financial grant, not to exceed \$500,000.

(e) In order to be eligible for the food justice frontline program, the nonprofit food security organization must submit an application that includes, but is not necessarily limited to:

(1) a detailed description of the program or programs which the nonprofit food security organization operates that provide land or food security jobs to low-income Massachusetts residents; and (2) a detailed description of the ways in which the nonprofit food security

organization would use funding to create jobs for individuals living within overburdened communities.

(f) The department shall establish regulations and guidelines regarding the process and criteria for approval of applications for the food justice frontline program. These regulations and guidelines shall prioritize applications from nonprofit food security organizations which demonstrate a clear and credible plan to quickly create food security jobs for individuals living within overburdened communities.

(g) Nonprofit food security organizations which receive a grant under the food justice frontline program must use the entirety of the grant money on programs which will create food security jobs for individuals living within overburdened communities. These jobs must pay an hourly wage of not less than the quotient of one divided by two thousand and four hundred (1/2,400), multiplied by the statewide per capita income, as calculated by the United States Census Bureau.

(h) A nonprofit food security organization may apply for multiple financial grants under the food justice frontline program.

(i) The department shall have the power to enter contracts, hire employees, hire contractors, promulgate rules and regulations, adjudicate administrative cases, or take any other lawful action in order to implement the food justice frontline program.

Section 2D. (a) The department, in consultation with the executive office of economic development and the executive office of housing and liveable communities, shall establish a program designed to increase public awareness of the availability of the supplemental nutrition assistance program, the healthy incentives program, and other similar food access programs for

low-income Massachusetts residents and food insecure Massachusetts residents. The department shall employ Massachusetts residents under the age of eighteen to promote public awareness of the supplemental nutrition assistance program. The department shall prioritize working with Massachusetts residents who live in overburdened communities or census block groups with a median household income that is below 80% of the statewide median household income. This program shall be conducted in languages which reflect the native languages spoken by members of relevant overburdened communities.

(b) The department may apply for any relevant federal programs administered by the United States department of agriculture to provide matching benefits to be deposited in the fund.

(c) The department shall promulgate rules and regulations to implement this program.